

This document is written with the intention of helping the author learn. Not only by teaching, but also in the scenario where a time traveler gifts it to their younger self. Other readers are also welcome, but be warned: this text is written for highly motivated, mathematically mature readers. Readers are expected to be able to supply rigorous proofs where they are omitted, try their hand at proving results before reading the given proofs, internalize the given proofs in their own terms, work out cases on their own, and so on. The author believes the best way to learn is with a mentor. The author knows there are easily available books far better than this document, in every respect, except that it lets the author do as they please.

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The Fundamental Theorem of Arithmetic

Fact (Principle of Induction). *Any non-empty subset of the positive integers contains a smallest element.*

Fact + Nomenclature. *Let d be a positive integer and m be an integer. Then, there exists a unique pair of integers q, r satisfying $m = dq + r$ and $0 \leq r < d$. We call q the quotient and r the remainder of the division of m by d . When $r = 0$, that is, when there exists an integer q with $m = dq$, we say that d divides m , that d is a divisor of m , or that m is divisible by d , and we write this relation as $d \mid m$.*

Nomenclature. *An integer $p \geq 2$ is called a prime number if its only divisors are 1 and p .*

Fact. *Each positive integer $n \geq 2$ is divisible by at least one prime number p .*

Fact (Primes don't materialize out of thin air). *Let p be a prime number, and let m, n be integers satisfying $p \mid mn$. Then, either $p \mid m$ or $p \mid n$.*

Proof. Without loss of generality, we may restrict our attention to positive m, n . By the principle of induction, we may suppose the theorem holds for all prime numbers p' smaller than p (and any n, m). Again by the principle of induction, we may suppose the theorem holds for all positive pairs m', n' with a smaller sum $m' + n' < m + n$ (and our fixed p). Applying division with remainder, we may suppose $0 \leq m, n < p$. We may now write $kp = mn$ for some integer $0 \leq k < p$.

Case 1. If $k = 0$ then either $m = 0$ or $n = 0$, and we have our desired conclusion.

Case 2. We cannot have $k = 1$, by p being a prime number.

Case 3. If $k \geq 2$, then we may pick some prime number q dividing k . In particular $q \mid mn$ and $q < p$. Thus, the (first) induction hypothesis, yields that either $q \mid m$ or $q \mid n$. Without loss of generality, we may assume $q \mid m$. We may write $k = qd$ and $m = qr$ for some positive integers d, r with $r < m$, yielding $dp = rn$. Thus, the (second) induction hypothesis yields that either $p \mid r$ (implying $p \mid m$) or $p \mid n$, reaching our desired conclusion. $\square$

Fact (Fundamental Theorem of Arithmetic). *Each positive integer n may be written as a product of a list of prime numbers $n = p_1 \dots p_\ell$, in a manner unique up to reordering of the terms.*

Number Theory - Exercises for Lecture 1

Fact. $d \mid m$ and $m \mid n$ implies $d \mid n$.

Fact. m and n have the same remainder with respect to division by d if and only if $d \mid m - n$.

Fact. The remainders of $m + n$ and of mn with respect to division by d depends only on the remainders of m and of n with respect to division by d .

Fact + Nomenclature. For a positive integer n and a prime number p , let the p -adic valuation $\nu_p(n)$ be the number of times we may divide n by p (until the result is no longer divisible by p). We have

$$n = \prod_p p^{\nu_p(n)}$$

Fact. We have $\nu_p(nm) = \nu_p(n) + \nu_p(m)$.

Fact. We have $\nu_p(n + m) \geq \min(\nu_p(n), \nu_p(m))$, and equality holds if $\nu_p(n) \neq \nu_p(m)$ (but not necessarily otherwise).

Fact. A positive integer is a perfect k -th power if and only if $k \mid \nu_p(n)$ for all prime numbers p . Deduce that the square root of 2 is irrational. More generally, the k -th root of a positive integer which is not a perfect k -th power, is irrational.

Fact. The number of divisors of n equals $\prod_p (\nu_p(n) + 1)$. In particular, n has an odd number of divisors if and only if n is a perfect square - convince a child of this.

Exercise. Search for Zarmelo's proof of the Fundamental Theorem of Arithmetic, which does not make use of the fact $p \mid mn \implies p \mid m$ or $p \mid n$.

TODO: fix lecture 1 given the following.

Nomenclature. We call a invertible modulo n if $0, a, 2a, 3a, \dots, (n-1)a$ cover all n distinct residue classes modulo n . Namely, if the row corresponding to a in the multiplication table modulo n contains each residue precisely once.

Fact. a is invertible modulo n if and only if there exists b such that $ab \equiv 1 \pmod{n}$. In that case, b is unique modulo n .

Fact. xy is invertible modulo n if and only if both x and y are invertible modulo n .

Fact. Let p be a prime number. Then each non-zero residue a is invertible modulo p .

Proof. By induction on $a = 1, \dots, p-1$. For $a = 1$ the result is clear. Assume the result holds for all previous a values. Divide p by a with remainder so that $p = aq + r$ for some $0 \leq r < a$. Since p is a prime number and $1 < a < p$, we have that $a \nmid p$ so $1 \leq r < a$, and thus the inductive hypothesis yields that $r \equiv -aq \pmod{p}$ is invertible modulo p , and hence so is a . $\square$

Nomenclature. The number of invertible residue classes modulo n is denoted $\varphi(n)$.

Fact. The multiplication table modulo n , reduced to the rows and columns of invertible residues modulo n (so that it has size $\varphi(n) \times \varphi(n)$), has only entries that are invertible modulo n , and moreover each row (and column) contains each invertible residues precisely once.

Fact. For each invertible residue class a modulo n we have $a^{\varphi(n)} \equiv 1 \pmod{n}$.

Proof. Let $x_1, \dots, x_{\varphi(n)}$ list the invertible residue classes modulo n . Then $ax_1, \dots, ax_{\varphi(n)}$ is a reordering of the same list. Therefore, the products of the two lists are equal, that is $x_1 \dots x_{\varphi(n)} \equiv ax_1 \dots ax_{\varphi(n)} = a^{\varphi(n)} x_1 \dots x_{\varphi(n)} \pmod{n}$. Since $x_1, \dots, x_{\varphi(n)}$ are invertible modulo n , we have $1 \equiv a^{\varphi(n)} \pmod{n}$ as desired. $\square$

Quadratic Residues and Quadratic Forms

Fact (Thue). *Let a be coprime to n , and $n \geq 2$. Then, there exists a solution to $ax \equiv y \pmod{n}$ with $0 < |x|, |y| < \sqrt{n}$.*

Proof. Consider all combinations $ax - y \pmod{n}$ where $x, y = 0, \dots, \lfloor \sqrt{n} \rfloor$. There are $(1 + \lfloor \sqrt{n} \rfloor)^2 > n$ such combinations, so by the pigeon hole principle there must be a repetition. So let $ax_1 - y_1 \equiv ax_2 - y_2$ where $(x_1, y_1) \neq (x_2, y_2)$. Since a is coprime to n , we must have that $x_1 \not\equiv x_2$ and $y_1 \not\equiv y_2$. Now $x = x_1 - x_2$ and $y = y_1 - y_2$ satisfy the requested requirements, as desired. $\square$

Fact. *Let $p \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$. Then, there exists x, y with $p = x^2 + y^2$.*

Proof. Let a solve $a^2 \equiv -1 \pmod{p}$. Applying Thue's result, let x, y solve $ax \equiv y \pmod{p}$ with $0 < |x|, |y| < \sqrt{p}$. Then $0 < x^2 + y^2 < 2p$ and $x^2 + y^2 \equiv x^2(1 + a^2) \equiv 0 \pmod{p}$, so $p = x^2 + y^2$ as desired. $\square$

Algebraic Integers

Fact. *A number which is both rational and an algebraic integer must be an integer.*

$$\mathbf{Q} \cap \overline{\mathbf{Z}} = \mathbf{Z}$$

Fact (Fundamental Theorem of Symmetric Polynomials). *Let $f(x_1, \dots, x_n)$ be a symmetric polynomial. Then, in fact, $f(x_1, \dots, x_n) = g(e_1, \dots, e_n)$ may be given as a polynomial expression in the elementary symmetric polynomials in $x_1, \dots, x_n$.*

Proof. We give a lexicographic ordering of monomials, so that $x_1^{i_1} \dots x_n^{i_n} >_{lex} x_1^{j_1} \dots x_n^{j_n}$ whenever $i_k > j_k$ for the first index k where $i_k \neq j_k$. This is a total order of all monomials. Suppose the lexicographically highest monomial term of $f(x_1, \dots, x_n)$ is $x_I = x_1^{i_1} \dots x_n^{i_n}$, and that the theorem holds for all symmetric polynomials containing terms only lexicographically smaller than this monomial. Since f is symmetric, we have $i_1 \geq \dots \geq i_n$. Now, $E_I = e_1^{i_1-i_2} e_2^{i_2-i_3} \dots e_{n-1}^{i_{n-1}-i_n} e_n^{i_n}$ has highest lexicographic monomial term equal to $x_1^{i_1-i_2} (x_1 x_2)^{i_2-i_3} \dots (x_1 \dots x_{n-1})^{i_{n-1}-i_n} (x_1 \dots x_n)^{i_n} = x_I$. Subtracting cE_I from f (where c is the coefficient of x_I in f) yields a symmetric polynomial, all of whose terms are lexicographically smaller than x_I , so by induction $f - cE_I$ is expressible as a polynomial in $e_1, \dots, e_n$, and thus so is f , as desired. $\square$

Fact. *Sums and products of algebraic integers are algebraic integers.*

Proof. Let α, β be algebraic integers. Then we may write

$$(x - \alpha_1) \dots (x - \alpha_m) = x^m + a_1 x^{m-1} + \dots + a_{m-1} x + a_m$$

$$(x - \beta_1) \dots (x - \beta_n) = x^n + b_1 x^{n-1} + \dots + b_{n-1} x + b_n$$

for integers a_i, b_j and numbers α_i, β_j with $\alpha = \alpha_1, \beta = \beta_1$. Consider the polynomials

$$\prod_{i,j} (x - (\alpha_i + \beta_j))$$

and

$$\prod_{i,j} (x - (\alpha_i \beta_j))$$

By the fundamental theorem of symmetric polynomials, each of these is expressible as a polynomial in x whose coefficients are polynomials in a_i, b_j . That is, these polynomials have integer coefficients. In particular, $\alpha + \beta$ and $\alpha\beta$ are algebraic integers, as desired. $\square$

Proof. Let $A \in \mathbf{Z}^{m \times m}$, $B \in \mathbf{Z}^{n \times n}$ be respectively the companion matrices of α, β . Let A have eigenvalues α_i with corresponding eigenvectors v_i , and let B have eigenvalues β_j with corresponding eigenvectors u_j . Then $A \otimes B \in \mathbf{Z}^{nm \times nm}$ and $A \otimes \text{id}_n + \text{id}_m \otimes B$ have respectively the eigenvalues $\alpha_i \beta_j$ and $\alpha_i + \beta_j$, both with corresponding eigenvectors $v_i \otimes u_j$. It follows that $\alpha_i \beta_j$ and $\alpha_i + \beta_j$ (and in particular $\alpha\beta$ and $\alpha + \beta$) are algebraic integers, as desired. $\square$

Cyclotomics

Nomenclature. The n -th cyclotomic polynomial is

$$\Phi_n(x) = \prod_{\mu \text{ a primitive } n\text{-th root of unity}} (x - \mu) = \prod_{j \in (\mathbf{Z}/n\mathbf{Z})^\times} (x - \zeta^j)$$

where $\zeta = e^{2\pi i/n}$.

Fact.

$$x^n - 1 = \prod_{d|n} \Phi_d(x)$$

Fact. $\Phi_n(x) \in \mathbf{Z}[x]$ is a monic integer polynomial.

Proof. Clearly $\Phi_n(x)$ is a monic polynomial. By induction, we have that $\Phi_n(x)$ is a rational function of x with rational coefficients, but it has no poles so it is a rational polynomial. $\Phi_n(x) \in \mathbf{Q}(x) \cap \mathbf{C}[x] = \mathbf{Q}[x]$. It is clear that the roots of $\Phi_n(x)$ are algebraic integers, so the coefficients of $\Phi_n(x)$ are algebraic integers that are rational numbers, and so $\Phi_n(x)$ has integer coefficients. $\Phi_n(x) \in \mathbf{Q}[x] \cap \overline{\mathbf{Z}}[x] = \mathbf{Z}[x]$. $\square$

Fact. $\Phi_n(x)$ is irreducible in $\mathbf{Q}[x]$.

Proof. (Schur) Recall that the discriminant of $x^n - 1$ is $\pm n^n$. Let $f(x)$ be the minimal polynomial of ζ over $\mathbf{Q}$. So $f(x) \in \mathbf{Z}[x]$ and $f(x) = (x - \zeta_1) \dots (x - \zeta_k)$ for some distinct n -th roots of unity $\zeta_1, \dots, \zeta_k$. We must show that the roots of $f(x)$ are closed under exponentiating by powers coprime to n . It suffices to show that if μ is a root of f and p is a prime coprime to n then μ^p is a root of f . We have that $f(\mu^p) = f(\mu^p) - f(\mu)^p = f(x^p) - f(x)^p \downarrow_{x=\mu} = pg(x) \downarrow_{x=\mu}$ for some $g(x) \in \mathbf{Z}[x]$, so that $p \mid f(\mu^p)$ over $\overline{\mathbf{Z}}$. Moreover, if we assume for the sake of contradiction that μ^p is not a root of f then $f(\mu^p) = (\mu^p - \zeta_1) \dots (\mu^p - \zeta_k)$ divides the discriminant $\pm n^n$ over $\overline{\mathbf{Z}}$. However, $p \mid \pm n^n$ over $\overline{\mathbf{Z}}$ implies $p \mid n$ over $\mathbf{Z}$, contrary to our assumption. This shows that μ^p is a root of f , as desired. $\square$

Fact. Let $\zeta = \zeta_{p^r}$, $K = \mathbf{Q}(\zeta)$, and $m = [K : \mathbf{Q}]$. We have

- $N_{K/\mathbf{Q}}(1 - \zeta) = p$
- $\langle 1 - \zeta \rangle$ is a prime ideal, lying over p . $(1 - \zeta)\mathcal{O}_K \cap \mathbf{Z} = p\mathbf{Z}$
- $(1 - \zeta^j)/(1 - \zeta) \in \mathcal{O}_K^\times$ for all $j \in (\mathbf{Z}/p^r\mathbf{Z})^\times$
- $p\mathcal{O}_K = (1 - \zeta)^m \mathcal{O}_K$
- $\mathbf{Z}[\zeta] \cap p\mathcal{O}_K = p\mathbf{Z}[\zeta]$
- $\mathcal{O}_K = \mathbf{Z}[\zeta]$

Fermat's Last Theorem

Theorem. (Wiles, Taylor, Taniyama, Shimura, Ribet, Frey, . . . , Fermat) Let $n \geq 3$. Then, any solution in rational numbers to the equation

$$x^n + y^n = z^n$$

is trivial, in the sense that $xyz = 0$.

Exercise. It suffices to prove the case $n = 4$ and the cases where $n = p$ is an odd prime. Also, we may assume x, y, z are pairwise relatively prime.

Exercise. There are algebraic integers on the unit circle other than the roots of unity.

However, such numbers have conjugates outside the unit circle.

Fact. Suppose $f(x) = \prod_{\alpha} (x - \alpha) \in \mathbf{Z}[x]$ is a monic polynomial with integer coefficients, all of whose roots lie in the closed unit circle. Then each roots α is either zero or a root of unity.

Proof. Without loss of generality $f(x)$ is irreducible, so it has no repeated roots. Let A be the companion matrix. Then A is diagonable, with eigenvalues all of absolute value at most one. Thus the matrices $(A^n)_{n \geq 1}$ are bounded. However, these are integer matrices. By the pigeonhole principle, we have $A^n = A^{n+k}$ for some $k > 0$. It follows that $\alpha^n = \alpha^{n+k}$, so either $\alpha = 0$ or α is a k -th root of unity. $\square$

Fact. Any unit u of $\mathbf{Q}(\zeta_p)$ may be written as $u = r\zeta^k$ for some real r and some integer k .

Fact. For any $\alpha \in \mathbf{Z}[\zeta_p]$ there is an integer a with $\alpha^p \equiv a \pmod{\langle 1 - \zeta \rangle^p}$.

Fact (Kummer). Let p be a regular prime. Then the $n = p$ case of FLT is true.

Proof. Let us write the equation in the form

$$x^p + y^p + z^p = 0$$

We have

$$\prod_{j=0}^{p-1} (x + \zeta^j y) = x^p + y^p = -z^p$$

And so

$$\prod_{j=0}^{p-1} \langle x + \zeta^j y \rangle = \langle z \rangle^p$$

First let us handle the case $p \nmid xyz$.

Claim. We claim that $\langle x + \zeta^j y \rangle$ are pairwise coprime.

Indeed, suppose $\mathfrak{q} \mid \langle x + \zeta^j y \rangle$, $\mathfrak{q} \mid \langle x + \zeta^k y \rangle$. Then $x + \zeta^j y, x + \zeta^k y \in \mathfrak{q}$. Thus $\zeta^k(1 - \zeta^{k-j})y \in \mathfrak{q} \implies y \in \mathfrak{q}$ or $1 - \zeta^t \in \mathfrak{q}$. However, if $y \in \mathfrak{q}$ then $x \in \mathfrak{q}$, but this contradicts x, y being coprime. It follows that $1 - \zeta^t \in \mathfrak{q}$. Now $1 - \zeta^t \sim 1 - \zeta$, and $\langle 1 - \zeta \rangle$

is prime, so $\mathfrak{q} = \langle 1 - \zeta \rangle$. Thus $z \in \langle 1 - \zeta \rangle$. Since $N(\langle 1 - \zeta \rangle) = p$, we get $p \mid z$, contradicting our hypothesis.

It follows that each of the ideals $\langle x + \zeta^j y \rangle$ is a p -th power. Now let $\langle x + \zeta y \rangle = \mathfrak{m}^p$. So $\mathfrak{m}$ has order dividing p in the class group. Since p is regular, $\mathfrak{m} = \langle \alpha \rangle$ must be principal. We have

$$x + \zeta y = u\alpha^p$$

for some unit u . We may write $u = r\zeta^k$ for some real r and integer k . We find an integer a with $\alpha^p \equiv a \pmod{\langle 1 - \zeta \rangle^p}$ so $\alpha^p \equiv a \pmod{p}$ and hence $x + \zeta y \equiv r\zeta^k a \pmod{p}$. Inverting by ζ^k and conjugating, we find

$$\zeta^{-k}(x + \zeta y) - \zeta^k(x + \zeta^{-1}y) \equiv 0 \pmod{p}$$

So consider the algebraic integer β with $\beta = p^{-1}(\zeta^{-k}x + \zeta^{1-k}y - \zeta^kx - \zeta^{k-1}y)$. Since $\mathcal{O}_K = \mathbf{Z}[\zeta]$ has integer basis $(1, \zeta, \dots, \zeta^{p-1})$ minus any particular one, if $\zeta^{-k}, \zeta^{1-k}, \zeta^k, \zeta^{k-1}$ were all distinct we'd get that $p \mid x, y$, contradicting our hypothesis.

Case 1. We have $k \equiv 0 \pmod{p}$. In this case $\langle 1 - \zeta \rangle^{p-1} = \langle p \rangle \ni (\zeta - \zeta^{-1})y = \zeta^{-1}(\zeta^2 - 1)y$. Since $\zeta^2 - 1 \sim 1 - \zeta$, we have $y \in \langle 1 - \zeta \rangle \cap \mathbf{Z} = p\mathbf{Z}$, contradicting our hypothesis.

Case 2. We have $k \equiv 1 \pmod{p}$. This is the same as the previous case with y replaced by x .

Case 3. We must have $2k \equiv 1 \pmod{p}$. Thus

$$p\beta\zeta^k = (x - y)(1 - \zeta)$$

Taking norms, we have $p \mid x - y$. By symmetry, $x \equiv y \equiv z \pmod{p}$ and so $0 \equiv 3x^p \pmod{p}$. Our assumption yields $p = 3$. However, for $3 \nmid x, y, z$ we have $0 = x^3 + y^3 + z^3 \equiv \pm 1 \pm 1 \pm 1 \pmod{9}$, a contradiction.

TODO handle case $p \mid xyz$ and prove lemmas. □

Gauss Sums and Quadratic Reciprocity

Let p be an odd prime, $\varepsilon_p = (-1)^{\frac{p-1}{2}}$, $p^* = \varepsilon_p p$, $\zeta = e^{2\pi i/p}$. Now, we set

$$\tau = \sum_{x \in \mathbf{F}_p} \zeta^{x^2}$$

We have

$$\tau^* = \sum_{y \in \mathbf{F}_p} \zeta^{-y^2}$$

If $\varepsilon_p = 1$ then -1 is a square modulo p and so $\tau^* = \tau$. Otherwise -1 is a non-square modulo p and so $\tau + \tau^* = 2 \sum_{w \in \mathbf{F}_p} \zeta^w = 0$. Thus

$$\tau^* = \varepsilon_p \tau$$

We have

$$\tau \tau^* = \sum_{x, y \in \mathbf{F}_p} \zeta^{x^2 - y^2} = \sum_{u, v \in \mathbf{F}_p} \zeta^{uv} = p$$

where we make use of the bijection $(x, y) \longleftrightarrow (u, v)$ given by $u = x + y$, $v = x - y$. It follows that

$$\tau = \pm \sqrt{p^*}$$

Fact. *We have*

$$\zeta = \sum_{a \in \mathbf{F}_p} (a : p) \zeta^a$$

Fact. *Let $a_0, \dots, a_{p-1}$ be integers with $\sum_j a_j \zeta^j = 0$. Then $a_0 = \dots = a_{p-1}$ are all equal.*

Definition 1. *Let $N_r(a) = \#\{(x_1, \dots, x_r) \in \mathbf{F}_p^r : x_1^2 + \dots + x_r^2 = a\}$.*

For example, we have $N_1(a) = 1 + (a : p)$.

Let r be even. Then

$$(p^*)^{r/2} = \tau^r = \sum_{x_1, \dots, x_r \in \mathbf{F}_p} \zeta^{x_1^2 + \dots + x_r^2} = \sum_{a \in \mathbf{F}_p} N_r(a) \zeta^a$$

So

$$N_r(0) - (p^*)^{r/2} = N_r(a) \quad \forall a \in \mathbf{F}_p^*$$

It follows (since $\sum_a N_r(a) = p^r$) that

$$N_r(a) = \begin{cases} p^{-1}(p^r - (p^*)^{r/2}) & a \neq 0 \\ p^{-1}(p^r + (p-1)(p^*)^{r/2}) & a = 0 \end{cases}$$

Let r be odd. Then

$$(p^*)^{(r-1)/2} \sum_{a \in \mathbf{F}_p} (a : p) \zeta^a = (p^*)^{(r-1)/2} \tau = \tau^r = \sum_{x_1, \dots, x_r \in \mathbf{F}_p} \zeta^{x_1^2 + \dots + x_r^2} = \sum_{a \in \mathbf{F}_p} N_r(a) \zeta^a$$

So that $N_r(a) - (p^*)^{(r-1)/2} (a : p) \equiv c$ is a constant. It follows that $c = p^{r-1}$ and so

$$N_r(a) = p^{r-1} + (p^*)^{(r-1)/2} (a : p)$$

Fact (Quadratic Reciprocity). *Let p, q be distinct odd primes. Then $(p : q)(q : p) = \varepsilon_p \varepsilon_q$.*

Proof. Let us consider $N_q(1) \pmod q$. On one hand, $N_q(1) = p^{q-1} + (p^*)^{(q-1)/2} \equiv 1 + (p^* : q) \pmod q$. On the other hand, the sphere $\{(x_1, \dots, x_q) \in \mathbf{F}_p^q : x_1^2 + \dots + x_q^2 = 1\}$ is acted on by C_q via cyclic rotations. It follows that $N_q(1) \equiv 1 + (q : p) \pmod q$. $\square$

Beta Function

Fact.

$$\int_0^1 p^k (1-p)^m = \frac{k!m!}{(k+m+1)!}$$

Proof. Consider the following stochastic process. First, generate $p \sim U[0, 1]$. Then, generate n independent Bernoulli(p) trials $b_1, \dots, b_n \sim \text{Ber}(p)$. What is the probability of having precisely k successes? The answer, of course, is

$$\int_0^1 \binom{n}{k} p^k (1-p)^{n-k} dp$$

However, instead of generating the b_i as Bernoulli trials out of thin air, let us generate $x_1, \dots, x_n \in U[0, 1]$ and set $b_i = [x_i < p]$. Then, the question asks what is the probability that precisely k of the n numbers $x_1, \dots, x_n$ come before p . Clearly, the ordering of $p, x_1, \dots, x_n$ is uniform over all permutations of $n+1$ terms, and so this probability is $\frac{1}{n+1}$ for each $k = 0, \dots, n$. $\square$

Finite Fields

Fact. *The field extension $\mathbf{F}_{q^m}/\mathbf{F}_q$ is cyclic; The Galois group is generated by the Frobenius automorphism $x \mapsto x^q$.*

Representation Theory

The Classical approach.

Fact (Weierstrass). *Let k be an algebraically closed field, and let A be a commutative k -algebra of finite dimension n over k , with no non-zero nilpotents. Then $A \cong k^n$.*

Proof. By induction on n . The case $n = 1$ is clear. Assume $n > 1$ and let $\zeta \in A \setminus k$. Let $m(x) \in k[x]$ be the minimal polynomial of ζ . Write $m(x) = \prod_j (x - r_j)^{a_j}$ with $r_j \in k$ and $a_j \geq 1$. Then $\prod_j (\zeta - r_j)$ is nilpotent. It follows that $a_j = 1$ for all j . Thus

$$k[\zeta] \cong k[x]/\langle m(x) \rangle \cong \prod_j k[x]/\langle x - r_j \rangle \cong k^d$$

where $d > 1$ is the degree of $m(x)$. It follows that we can find orthogonal idempotents $e_1, \dots, e_d$ spanning $k[\zeta]$. Thus A decomposes as

$$A = e_1 A \oplus \dots \oplus e_d A$$

and we're done by induction. □

Thus we'd like a criterion ruling out the existence of non-zero nilpotents in our commutative algebra A . Now, if x is nilpotent, then so is xy , and so is the multiplication $m_{xy} \in \text{End}_k(A)$, and thus $\text{Tr } m_{xy} = 0$ for all $y \in A$. We notice that $\langle x, y \rangle = \text{Tr } m_{x,y}$ is a symmetric bilinear form $A \times A \rightarrow k$.

Fact. *Let k be field, and let A be a commutative k -algebra of finite dimension n over k . If the form $\langle x, y \rangle = \text{Tr } m_{xy}$ is non-degenerate, then A has no non-zero nilpotents.*

Fact (Frobenius). *Let G be a finite group with s conjugacy classes. Then $Z(\mathbf{C}[G]) \cong \mathbf{C}^s$.*

Proof. By Weierstrass' theorem, we need only show $Z(\mathbf{C}[G])$ has no non-zero nilpotents. By the trace condition, we need only show that $\langle x, y \rangle = \text{Tr } m_{xy}$ is non-degenerate. So we shall show that $\det(\langle e_i, e_j \rangle)_{ij} \neq 0$ for a basis of $Z(\mathbf{C}[G])$. Let us write $C_1, \dots, C_s$ for the conjugacy classes of G . For a class C_γ , let $e_\gamma = \sum_{g \in C_\gamma} g$. Then $(e_\gamma)_{\gamma=1}^s$ forms a basis of $Z(\mathbf{C}[G])$. We have

$$e_k e_j = e_j e_k = \sum_i a_{ijk} e_i$$

where

$$a_{ijk} = \#\{(b, c) \in C_j \times C_k : bc = a\}$$

for any fixed $a \in C_i$. Letting M_γ be the $s \times s$ matrix representing multiplication by e_γ , we have

$$(M_\gamma)_{\alpha, \beta} = a_{\alpha\beta\gamma}$$

and thus

$$\langle e_\alpha, e_\beta \rangle = \text{Tr } M_\alpha M_\beta = \sum_{\gamma, \delta} a_{\gamma\delta\alpha} a_{\delta\gamma\beta}$$

Now, we let

$$h_{ijk} = \#\{(a, b, c) \in C_i \times C_j \times C_k : abc = e\}$$

Since $abc = e \iff bca = e$, we have $h_{ijk} = h_{jki}$. Since $abc = e \iff b(b^{-1}ab)c = e$, we have $h_{ijk} = h_{jik}$. Thus h is symmetric in its variables. For a conjugacy class C_i , we write $C_{i'}$ for the inverse class $\{c^{-1} : c \in C_i\}$. Since $abc = e \iff c^{-1}b^{-1}a^{-1} = e$, we have $h_{ijk} = h_{i'j'k'}$. Let us write

$$h_i = \#C_i$$

so that $h_i = h_{i'}$ and

$$a_{ijk}h_i = h_{i'jk}$$

We are now in position to verify the trace condition $\det\langle e_\alpha, e_\beta \rangle \neq 0$. Permuting the columns, we swap $\beta \leftrightarrow \beta'$. Let

$$P_{\alpha\beta} := \langle e_\alpha, e_{\beta'} \rangle = \sum_{\gamma, \delta} a_{\gamma\delta\alpha} a_{\delta\gamma\beta'} = \sum_{\gamma, \delta} \frac{h_{\gamma'\delta\alpha} h_{\delta'\gamma\beta'}}{h_\gamma h_\delta} = \sum_{\gamma, \delta} \frac{h_{\gamma\delta\alpha} h_{\gamma\delta\beta}}{h_\gamma h_\delta}$$

where in the last step we used $\gamma \leftrightarrow \gamma'$. Let Q be the real $s \times s^2$ matrix

$$Q_{\alpha, (\gamma, \delta)} = \frac{h_{\gamma\delta\alpha}}{\sqrt{h_\gamma h_\delta}}$$

so that

$$P = QQ^t$$

So showing that P is nonsingular reduces to showing that Q has rank s . Indeed, let γ_0 be such that $C_{\gamma_0} = \{e\}$. Then the submatrix $Q_{\alpha, (\gamma_0, \delta)} = \sqrt{h_\delta}[\alpha = \delta']$ is non-singular. $\square$